



Twisting flax fibers made them stronger.

34,000 BCE

Earliest flax fibers

Twisted fibers of flax (a type of plant) found in a cave in Georgia, in the Caucasus region between Europe and Asia, are evidence that humans had learned how to use plant fibers to make rope or cord by 34,000 BCE. Some of the fibers had been dyed to look colorful.

18,000 BCE

Pottery making

People made the first pots with clay, which they shaped and hardened in a fire. These vessels were used for cooking or storing food. The earliest ones found, dated to around 18,000 BCE, come from China. By 14,000 BCE, the Jomon people of Japan were making pottery on a large scale.



Jomon pottery vessel from Japan



Mouflon, an early breed of sheep

8500 BCE

Animal domestication

Early farmers began to keep and breed animals, rather than simply hunting them. The first species to be domesticated in this way were sheep and goats, which provided a reliable source of food.

35,000

Narrow needles with pointed end for penetrating animal hide



30,000 BCE

Bone needles

The use of sharpened bone needles began to spread, suggesting that people had learned how to sew. There is some evidence from China, Africa, and parts of Europe that simple bone needles were used as early as 63,000 BCE, although their purpose is uncertain.

10,500 BCE

Domesticating plants

Farming began when villagers at Abu Hureyra, Syria, deliberately sowed seeds of wild rye and einkorn (a type of wheat). People harvested these cereals as an extra source of food that could be gathered without a long foraging trip.

Farming begins
See pages 10–11

8000

8000 BCE

First log boat

Humans must have used boats to reach Australia around 50,000 BCE, but the oldest surviving boat, dating from 8000 BCE, is a canoe found in the Netherlands. Like many early watercraft, it was made by digging out a seating platform from a large log.

“From the terrace see the planted and fallow fields, the ponds and orchards.”

The Epic of Gilgamesh, a poem from Mesopotamia (present-day Iraq) dating from c 2000 BCE

Wood cut away from log to make seating area



The earliest boats closely resembled this Native American dugout canoe.